

SenaMUN V

Historical Security Council: Addressing the Russian Civil War



Serviço De Aprendizagem Comercial

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Summary

Summary	2
Welcome Letter	3
The Russian Civil War Introduction	5
Guiding Questions	7
Background Information	8
Historical Contextualization	11
Past actions	16
Current situation	17
Position of the Main Members	19
Historical Events and Acts	30
Glossary	33
List of Countries	36
Bibliography	38

Welcome Letter

Dear Delegates,

I, Marina de Anna, am thrilled to serve you as Head Chair and welcome you all to the Historical Security Council along with my incredible co-chairs Livia and Cauê! This Security Council will address a very complex, profound and history changing topic, making it a very challenging and rich committee. For this conference, you all will be challenged to explore and debate the complexity evolving the Russian Civil War, a very intricate and important topic!

I cherish a deep passion for diplomacy, debating and MUN's, and couldn't be more excited to foster an environment where you can develop your diplomatic skills and fully immerse yourselves into such an important discussion! This conference offers a unique and special opportunity for participants to engage in meaningful debates, with respect and diplomacy.

I am more than excited to get to meet you all and see what you have prepared for the conference. MUN's can be very intimidating at times, but it has the beautiful power of creating unforgettable memories and long-lasting knowledge.

When researching and preparing for this conference, be sure to go into depth to all the complex and nuanced issues, so you can fully understand your position and debate with confidence, ensuring a truly engaging and fruitful debate. I am sure you will all excel and surpass my expectations!

If you have any doubts regarding the study guide, the conference format, or any other matters, feel free to contact me through email or WhatsApp and I will be happy to clarify your concerns.

Kindest regards,
Marina de Anna

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Dear Delegates,

My name is Livia Chiavone, and I couldn't be more excited to welcome you to the Historical Security Council. Alongside my fellow chairs, I am looking forward to seeing your ideas, strategies, and perspectives throughout this committee. MUN's has always been a space where I have learned, grown, and created incredible memories, and I hope this committee can offer the same experience to each of you.

This year, we will explore the Russian Civil War in 1919, a challenging and important moment in history filled with conflicts, political struggles, and decisions

that changed the course of a nation. As delegates, you will get the chance to step into the roles of historical figures and navigate one of the most significant moments of the twentieth century. Given the limited time of our discussions, preparation will be essential. I encourage all delegates to research their positions, understand the historical context, and come ready to debate while adapting to the flow of the committee. Above all, remember to enjoy the experience. MUN is not only about debate, but also about learning, growing, and creating great memories. I am very excited to meet all of you and see what you bring to our committee! If you have any questions about the study guide, the committee, or anything else, feel free to contact me through email or WhatsApp. I'll be happy to help!

Best regards,
Livia Chiavone

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Dear Delegates,

My name is Cauê Garcia and I couldn't be more honored to be a chair of this year's Historical Security Council alongside Livia and Marina. This committee will address one of the most impactful events of all of modern history: The Russian Civil War, a conflict that was a product of decades of economical, social and political relations and summarizes early 20th century Europe.

Due to the complexity of this topic, I encourage all delegates to deeply research and comprehend it, fully grasping your position and being confident about it are the first steps to immerse yourself and enjoy the experience of a MUN.

I'm excited to meet you all and see what you've prepared for this committee. MUN's can be an intimidating experience but also can produce long-lasting memories and widen our knowledge.

If you have any doubts regarding the study guide, the conference format, or any other matters, feel free to contact me through WhatsApp and I will be glad to help!

Best regards,
Cauê Garcia

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The Russian Civil War Introduction

Figure 1 – The 1917 Peasant Revolutions



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The Russian Civil War was a complex and pivotal conflict in world history that took place in the former Russian Empire between 1918 and 1921. Years of accumulated tension, triggered by disastrous failures in World War I, severe food and fuel shortages, and deep public distrust of Tsar Nicholas II's autocratic regime led to the outbreak of the conflict, reaching the point of no return after the events of 1917. The February Revolution (1917) deposed the autocratic tsarist regime, with the formation of a provisional government aimed at addressing the nation's political and social instability. However, dissatisfaction remained present all over the population, as the Provisional Government decided to continue participating in the Great War, along with the overall discontent caused by the poor management of the social and economic crisis. In this rather delicate scenario, the Bolsheviks came about with the October Revolution, overthrowing the Russian Provisional Government under the leadership of Vladimir Lenin, quickly sparking opposition. War then arose with

different factions battling each other in order to determine which group and their respective ideology would be the one to definitively rule Russia.

Immersed in this complex and multilateral battle for power, four different groups gained special highlight and defined what would become a major conflict that reshaped global politics to its core. The main ones being — the Bolsheviks, or the Red Army — were composed of a group of Marxists-Leninists who had as their main goal the will to create the so-called “*dictatorship of the proletariat*”. As the main opposition to the Red Army, the White Movement (or White Army) emerged as a coalition of liberals, monarchists, moderate socialists, and conservatives with a common anti-Bolshevik goal. The Greens also came into the picture, differing from the other groups, as they were not a properly centralized army, but rather a group of peasants and communal villages against both the Red and White armies, while also seeking to keep the land expropriated from the nobility. And, finally, the Black Army, an anarchist-communist Ukrainian movement that fought against the Whites for the creation of a stateless soviet society (Free Soviets).

The growing rivalry and intensifying tension between these groups quickly escalated the war, and, now, set in September of 1919, as the White Army initiates yet another offensive against the Bolsheviks, the Russian Civil War reaches its peak at a critical moment. With political instability and social crisis intensifying, international cooperation has never been more urgent, placing this committee in a decisive position to influence the outcome of such a complex conflict.

The Russian Civil War

Guiding Questions

- 1) What was the Russian Civil War, and what were its main characteristics?
- 2) How does your delegation deal with the crescent possibility of a soviet victory?
- 3) What measures can be taken to mitigate and end the impacts of the war?
- 4) What type of government does your delegation support or stand against and why?
- 5) How should the independence movements rise throughout the war be dealt with?

Figure 2 – A view of a bloody sunday.



Font – Art by Vladimirov Ivan on Wikimedia

Background Information

The Russian Civil War is one of the most complex conflicts in modern history, shaped by a series of external and internal factors that gradually deepened the political and social tensions within the former Russian Empire until reaching the final point of collapse. To fully understand the War and its impacts on not only Russia, but all the globe, it is important to comprehend one of the decisive events that culminated in the outburst of the conflict; the February and October revolutions — along with the factors that led to them.

When analyzing the external elements that led to the 1917 revolutions and, consequently, the Civil War, three elements come to focus: the Great War, the rise of Communist movements around the globe, and organizations throughout Europe, marked by the intensification of imperialism.

The early 20th century was not only shaped by the expressive expansion of capitalism towards Africa and Asia but also by the growing tensions amongst major powers in pursuit of consolidating their sphere of influence. In this context, among several European nations battling for dominance, Germany arose as the greater threat to all of Europe, with its ever-growing industries and remarkable military, even capable of rivaling Britain's. With such force and capability, the Nation began to expand its influence towards Africa and, especially, the Balkans — Russia's main zone of influence. With the recent expansion of German dominance over regions once under Russian influence, industrialization soon became an urgent matter to be addressed. The German threat forced Tsarist Russia into a quick, chaotic, and poorly organized industrialization process, leading to a greater disparity between rural and urban populations, along with the remarkable worsening of work conditions in factories.

Additionally, the expansion of European capitalism served as yet another source of great pressure on the proletariat in the pursuit of maximized productivity. This constant pressure, combined with the poor and harsh work conditions endured by workers every day, led to a crescendo of popular dissatisfaction, contributing to the rise of several working-class movements around Europe — such as the Labour Party in Britain, the Social Democratic Party of Germany, and the Bolsheviks in Russia. These movements, except the Labour Party, were associated with the "Second International", a global socialist organization aimed at coordinating proletarian movements and supporting the production of socialist propaganda and theory. In this context, on the eve of the Great War, many members of the Second

International saw Russia as the “weak link” of capitalism due to its political instability, widespread oppression, and social unrest. Challenging the Marxist idea that the socialist revolution would first emerge in the most capitalist states, members then saw in Russia’s uneven development of capitalism a potential catalyst for a broader pan-European socialist revolution.

When the Great War finally ended, major European powers saw in the conflict an opportunity to properly deal with their adversaries, expand markets, and strengthen popular support for their governments. In Russia, it was no different. The Empire was already struggling with overall popular dissatisfaction: the Imperial Army remained heavily demoralized after great losses at the Russo-Japanese and Crimean Wars, Russian influence in the Balkans kept declining, and the workers — now organized as Soviets — grew more and more disappointed over not only work conditions, but the broader structure of the Empire. The Tsarist government, then, believed that entering the War would be a possible way to overcome internal crisis and restore national unity and support.

However, reality took a different turn, and the effects of the newfound Russian participation in the War grew to be the exact opposite of what was idealized. Any hopes of success soon faded away as the heavy losses on the Eastern Front, coupled with the implementation of scorched-earth tactics, served to intensify famine and deepen the Empire's state of economic and political crisis, which would, afterwards, lead to the February Revolution.

The February Revolution resulted in the fall of the autocratic regime of the Tsars and the formation of a provisional government composed of liberals and moderate socialists.

Popular discontent persisted in Russia due to continued participation in World War I and a severe economic and social crisis. Taking advantage of this discontent, the Bolsheviks, led by Vladimir Lenin, instigated the October Revolution of 1917, seizing power and establishing a communist government. This provoked immediate opposition from various political groups, including the “Whites” (counter-revolutionaries), monarchists, liberals, nationalists, moderate socialists, and separatist groups.

The “Whites” constituted a diverse and decentralized coalition, united solely by the objective of overthrowing the Bolsheviks. Their leaders included former officers of the Tsarist army, such as Admiral Kolchak and General Denikin, as well as

prominent political figures like Pavel Milyukov, leader of the Constitutional Democratic Party (Cadet).

The lack of ideological and strategic unity compromised the military and political effectiveness of the Bolsheviks' opponents during the Russian Civil War. Beyond the confrontation between the "Reds" (Bolsheviks) and the "Whites," the conflict was marked by various regional conflicts and separatist movements. Several regions and ethnic groups sought autonomy or independence from the central government in Moscow, resulting in the fragmentation of the country. Among these conflicts, the struggles of the Bolsheviks against Ukrainian nationalists, Cossacks, Baltic peoples, and others stand out.

The Russian Civil War was internationalized by the intervention of several foreign powers. Countries such as Great Britain, France, Japan, and the United States supported the "White" forces, intending to contain the expansion of communism.

Foreign interventions in the Russian Civil War were largely poorly coordinated and, in some cases, counterproductive, strengthening the Bolsheviks' resolve to resist external interference. Simultaneously, the Bolsheviks established the Red Army under the leadership of Leon Trotsky and adopted policies of total war to ensure their survival, including the intensive mobilization of human and material resources, as well as the application of rigorous methods and forced conscription.

The Russian Civil War was characterized by atrocities committed by both sides, including mass executions, massacres of prisoners, and violent repression in regions considered sympathetic to the enemy. Furthermore, famine and disease spread, exacerbated by the conflict and the "war on the peasantry" policy adopted by the Bolsheviks.

Historical Contextualization

Although they were a direct consequence of the global dynamics of the early 20th century, the 1917 revolutions and the Russian Civil War would never have taken place if not for Russia's own unique economic, cultural and political characteristics. Compared to other European nations, Russia had historically lagged behind: while the foundations of capitalism were already consolidating themselves throughout Europe, Russia had only recently achieved its national consolidation. Such historical backwardness would mark Russian — and the World's — history ever since, ultimately becoming the main factor that turned the Empire into what many socialists considered the "weak link" of capitalism.

Throughout this vast and complex period, Russia remained under the rule of the Romanov dynasty, the royal family that had governed the Empire since 1613. Over more than three long centuries in power, the Romanovs were crucial to Russia's rise as one of Europe's largest empires while also maintaining a strongly centralized and deeply autocratic political system. By the beginning of the twentieth century, however, the legitimacy of the monarchy began to raise more and more questions as Tsar Nicholas II encountered ever-growing trouble governing Russia, a country immersed in growing economic, social and political instability. Unlike many Western European monarchs, who had gradually accepted constitutional limitations to their authority, Nicholas II remained firmly committed to preserving the traditional powers of the Tsar, believing that his authority derived from divine right rather than from the will of the population. As dissatisfaction continued to grow free and quickly, the Romanov dynasty turned into the central pillar of the structural problems affecting the Russian Empire, ultimately turning the monarchy into one of the main targets of popular discontent.

Up until the mid-19th century, Russia still remained a predominantly feudal nation, consisting mainly of peasants, landlords and a small merchant class. However, Russian serfdom proved to be considerably harsher than its European counterpart. The peasants — especially those living in private lands, nearly 40% of the population of Tsarist Russia — possessed no land of their own and lacked even the freedom to leave their estates or break ties with their landlords. Much like slaves, serfs were treated as property, freely bought and sold by landowners. Such conditions led to several popular uprisings and rebellions throughout the Empire, all of which were rapidly repressed by the Tsarist government. Serfdom would only be officially abolished in 1861 and, despite the new legislation, many landlords — and

even the State itself — continued to practice it until its complete abolition and proper fiscalization in 1881.

When it comes to industrialization, Russia also experienced a remarkably late development process. Due to the absence of consolidated urban centers with manufacturers and producers, the Empire failed to witness the emergence of a strong national bourgeoisie and, consequently, lacked a domestic class capable of investing in industries and infrastructure. Industrial development reached Russia mainly through foreign investments, especially French and British ones, as both powers feared the growing German threat and sought another ally in the event of a future conflict. Such dependence on foreign capital created a bourgeoisie with little actual influence within Russian politics and society. When describing this phenomenon, Leon Trotsky stated that “The twofold imperialism of the Russian bourgeoisie had basically the character of an agency for other mightier world powers.” It was precisely this lack of popular influence that drove both peasants and workers away from liberalism and made them increasingly susceptible to radical political ideas. Furthermore, Russian industrialization, due to its rapid and poorly coordinated nature, generated several structural problems within Russian society. The widening gap between social classes, combined with the concentration of industrial workers in only a few urban centers, created a growing atmosphere of dissatisfaction among the proletariat, who had to endure worsening working conditions while possessing little to no foreseeable prospects of improvement.

As Russian society grew increasingly dissatisfied with the Tsarist regime, it became only a matter of time before another major uprising emerged. On January 22nd, 1905, a peaceful mass of workers protesting in front of the Tsar’s palace was brutally massacred by the Imperial Guard. The event, later known as “Bloody Sunday”, became the catalyst for a wave of strikes throughout the Empire, with both Moscow and St. Petersburg entering general strike. The workers demanded better working conditions, greater political representation, expansion of voting rights and an end to censorship and political repression. In response to the growing instability, the Tsar issued the “October Manifesto”, a pledge aimed at meeting part of the proletariat’s demands and establishing a constitution.

Other impactful outcomes of the Revolution of 1905 were the creation of the St. Petersburg Soviet and the establishment of the Duma. The Soviet emerged as an organization of industrial workers responsible for debating and guiding the struggles of the working class. It was heavily influenced by both the Socialist Revolutionary Party and the Russian Social Democratic Labour Party, organizations that opposed the monarchy and defended the creation of a socialist state in Russia. The Duma, on

the other hand, was established as a lower house of the Russian parliament with the power to propose and vote on laws. Nevertheless, although it had originally been created with the intent of granting the population greater political participation, the institution failed to substantially alter Russia's status quo, as the Tsar still maintained his autocratic powers.

Not long after issuing the "October Manifesto", the Tsar ratified the Constitution of 1906 in an attempt to appease the growing tensions between the government and the population. However, due to its deeply autocratic nature, the constitution ultimately served to divide Russian society even further. The "Octobrists" aligned themselves with the government and believed that the recently established constitution was enough to stabilize the Empire, opposing the creation of a constituent assembly. On the other hand, the social democrats — also known as the "Kadets" — rejected the constitution and defended the creation of such assembly, believing that the reforms proposed by the Tsarist government were insufficient to properly address Russia's structural problems. However, such political division did not limit itself to the opposition between conservatives and liberals. The Kadets themselves rapidly became divided between those who believed the Tsarist regime should be completely overthrown and those who still defended gradual reforms as a possible solution to Russia's instability. As ideological tensions continued to intensify amongst conservatives, liberals and revolutionaries alike, Russian society grew increasingly polarized, a process that would continue to shape both the Duma and the broader political scenario of the Empire until the outbreak of the Civil War.

And, finally, the 1917 revolutions. Immersed into this complex, fragile and rather volatile scenario built by both external and internal factors, as previously explored, a sign of change rose in Petrograd, starting what would later receive the name of "February Revolution".

By the start of 1917, Russia was already in a state of deep, structural and severe instability. In Petrograd — one of the Empire's most industrialized cities and center of many workers' demonstrations — the effects of the Great War and the political structures of the Empire itself became increasingly devastating, accumulating tensions up until the breaking point. In February, in the midst of a harsh winter — combined with snowstorms, delayed firewood and food delivery, intensifying famine and popular dissatisfaction — the people gave the official start to the Revolution. What started as protests in fear of hunger quickly developed into openly political demonstrations against the Tsarist government as demands changed and no perspective of change rose to the horizon.

As protests continued to grow, the Revolution rapidly escalated into a larger popular uprising. Duma's attempts of regaining control and restoring order were thwarted, and revolutionaries managed to seize arsenals, free political prisoners and take control over important industrial centers all over the capital. In face of such collapse of state authority, the Tsarist Nicholas II saw himself forced to abdicate, marking the official dissolution of the Tsardom.

The abdication of Nicholas II officially brought the long-lasting three centuries of Romanov rule to an end. However, that was not the final pawn to determine the destiny of the family. Following the February Revolution, Nicholas II, Empress Alexandra and their five children were initially placed under house arrest by the Provisional Government before being transferred by the Bolsheviks to several locations in the Russian interior as the Civil War gradually intensified. As the White Army advanced through different regions of the country, Bolshevik authorities became increasingly concerned that the Romanovs could be rescued and transformed into a powerful symbol capable of rallying monarchist forces against the new revolutionary government. In this context, during the night of 16 July 1918, Nicholas II, Alexandra, their five children and attendants were executed in the Ipatiev House, in Yekaterinburg. The executions marked the definitive end of the Romanov dynasty once and for all and eliminated the strongest dynasty to ever claim the Russian throne. Nevertheless, the murder of the imperial family raised intense emotions and became one of the most controversial episodes of the Russian Civil War, even intensifying anti-Bolshevik sentiment both within and beyond Russia, while also deepening and polarizing even more the political and ideological divisions that defined the conflict.

Immediately following the revolution, a new Provisional Government was formed, made up by members of the Duma and led by George Lvov. Despite the intentions, the government had no proper constitutional authority and was seen to represent the interests of the privileged. Additionally, its influence was also limited due to the 'Dual Power' — power was shared with another body, the Petrograd Soviet Workers and Soldier Deputies, an assembly of over 500 members that was popularly seen as more representative. Despite the attempts on liberal reforms over the following months to gain popular support, the Provisional Government made the final decision of not taking Russia out of the Great War, one of the main causes of the February Revolution. This would then become the central factor that led to the second revolution, in October of the same year.

Following the collapse of Tsarist rule during the February Revolution, Russia entered another period of profound political instability marked by the

implementation of the dual power solution. However, despite the initial attempts to bring stability to the Nation, such arrangement only deepened the ongoing political and social crisis. This precarious scenario — poor conditions of living, food shortages, mass unemployment — was only aggravated by the decision of the Provisional Government to continue fighting the Great War, amplifying popular dissatisfaction. Consequently, mass demonstrations became more and more frequent, often leaded by the Bolsheviks, gradually consolidating themselves as one of the main revolutionary forces within all Russia. Seeing the opportunity to take power, the Revolutionary Military Committee was born within the Petrograd Soviet, planning and organizing an armed uprising in Petrograd.

In October of 1917, the Bolsheviks finally launched their insurrection against the Provisional Government and, led by the Red Guards, the revolutionary forces quickly took control over several major governmental facilities while facing little to no effective resistance. During this historical uprising that forever changed Russia's history, Vladimir Lenin officially announced the seizure of power by the Revolutionary Military Committee. Later on the same day, Bolshevik insurgents surrounded the Winter Palace and, completely trapped, the Provisional Government members finally decided to surrender and give up their powers. That was the final move for the consolidation of Bolshevik control over Russia.

Past actions

When analyzing the past actions throughout the Civil War, Allied intervention stands out as one of the most significant. Soon after the outbreak of the conflict, British, French, Japanese, Italian and American troops were sent into Russian territory in the pursuit of overthrowing the Bolshevik government, protecting economic interests and restoring the Eastern Front.

When Russia entered the Great War, both its population and the Allied powers were aware that the Imperial Army was incapable of properly standing against German forces. As a result, Russia's role in the conflict became largely one of distraction, draining German resources and manpower away from the Western Front as its soldiers were continuously sacrificed in costly military campaigns. In this context, the signing of the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk generated great concern amongst the Allies, who feared that Germany would not only gain access to Russian supplies but also be able to fully redirect its military efforts towards Western Europe.

Economic interests also played a decisive role in motivating intervention. France, the United Kingdom and Japan were amongst the nations with the greatest interests in Russia. Both France and Britain had heavily invested in the Russian industrialization process and feared that the nationalization of industries promoted by the Bolsheviks would threaten those investments, especially in the coal mines of Ukraine and the oil fields of the Caucasus. Furthermore, supporting the White movement also represented an opportunity to increase their influence over Russia's future reconstruction while deepening its economic dependence.

Regarding Japan, its intervention was driven not only by a strong nationwide anti-communist sentiment but also by a long history of disputes over Siberian territories. In this context, Japanese authorities viewed Siberia as a strategically important region and considered its control essential for guaranteeing national security.

Although Allied intervention initially emerged from the desire to restore the Eastern Front, the end of the Great War soon altered its objectives. With Germany no longer posing an immediate threat, foreign powers gradually shifted their focus towards overthrowing the Bolshevik government and preventing the spread of communism throughout Europe.

Current situation

Soon after the Bolshevik rise to power, the newfound government quickly sought to sign a peace treaty with the Central Powers, aiming to properly remove Russia from the Great War and bring the long awaited stability to the newly formed Russian Socialist Federative Soviet Republic. This treaty, known as the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, managed to put an effective end to the conflict on the Eastern Front — but the prices were high. In return, Russia not only had to pay Germany war reparations of six billion marks, but also cede territories bordering the Central Powers, losing control over Ukraine, Poland, Latvia, Lithuania, Belarus and Estonia. It wasn't a simple trade, as altogether, those territories comprised 34% of Russia's population, 54% of its industrial lands, 89% of its coalfields and 26% of its railways.

Despite the popularity obtained within the proletariat and lower divisions, the satisfaction was not unanimous. The peace treaty deeply upset the monarchists, liberals and moderate socialists — prompting these groups to unite in an anti-bolshevik movement, known as the White Movement or Whites.

As Russian political groups progressively drifted apart from one another and socioeconomic turmoil continued to deepen throughout the former Empire, the prospect of Civil War increasingly loomed on the horizon. By 1918, political tensions had reached such a degree that a single event could descend Russian society into a full-blown conflict. This event came in May of that year with the revolt of the Czechoslovak Legion, a military division composed of Austro-Hungarian deserters that rose against the Bolsheviks following the signing of the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk. Beginning in the region of Vladivostok, the uprising rapidly expanded throughout Siberia, allowing the Legion to seize control over strategic railway networks and progressively take possession of the Trans-Siberian Railway as it sought to flee towards Europe.

The Whites, taking advantage of the revolt, managed to consolidate their control over Siberia and soon began preparations for an offensive towards Moscow. Alongside them, American, Japanese, British and French troops landed in Vladivostok seeking not only to reopen the Eastern Front, but also overthrow the Bolshevik government. With the military support of both the Legion and Allied forces, the Whites managed to attain several victories against the Bolsheviks.

In face of many consecutive losses, the Bolsheviks found themselves in dire necessity of change, as the Red Guard lacked proper military training and combat experience due to its paramilitary nature. It was in this context that Leon Trotsky,

acting as Commissar of War, instituted a series of reforms that completely overhauled the Red Guard, such as mandatory conscription, the reintegration of Tsarist officers and Non-Commissioned Officer (NCOs), the hierarchization of the military, the establishment of a clear chain of command and the introduction of multi-purposed armored trains, known as Zaamurets. These reforms ultimately transformed the Red Guard into an actual and proper army and allowed Soviet Russia to preserve the remaining territory under its control by September 1919, when it found itself surrounded by White forces and on the brink of losing the war.

Position of the Main Members

Russian Empire



Russia was the center of the Russian Civil War, a conflict that followed the October Revolution of 1917.

The struggle for control of the vast Russian territory was crucial to the consolidation of Bolshevik power and the formation of the new Soviet state.

During the civil war, the Russian Empire no longer existed as a political entity, having been replaced by the communist government of the Bolsheviks after the revolution. Before that, the Empire was an autocratic monarchy ruled by the Tsars, who sought to maintain dominion over diverse territories and populations. However, in the civil war, different factions vied for power, and the objectives of the former Empire lost relevance.

The Bolsheviks, responsible for the fall of the Tsarist regime, focused on consolidating their communist government and implementing their revolutionary policies. In contrast, anti-Bolshevik groups, such as the Whites, aimed to restore Tsarism or establish a democratic alternative. Thus, it is not appropriate to attribute the objectives of the Russian Empire to the Russian Civil War, given the profound change in political dynamics and the actors involved.

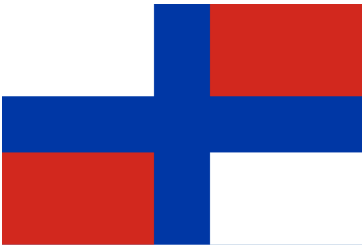
Representative of the Bolsheviks

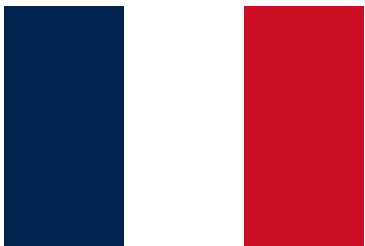


The Bolsheviks were a revolutionary and political force in Russia composed of its proletariat, low-ranking military personnel, rural workers, intellectuals and radicalized sectors of society who were dissatisfied with the Tsardom.

Led by Vladimir Lenin and heavily influenced by Marxist ideals, they sought to establish a socialist state in order to mitigate and deal with Russia's current crisis.

Their main goals were the socialization of the means of production, agrarian reform, equitable distribution of wealth and resources, strengthening of

	Russia's national sovereignty and independence from foreign capital. During the conflict, they faced opposition from anti-Soviet groups, foreign intervention, and internal revolts, but managed to consolidate their control through mass mobilization, revolutionary propaganda, and the Red Army. Simultaneously, they sought to expand their influence internationally, promoting world revolution and supporting revolutionary movements in other countries. In short, the Bolsheviks aspired to a radical transformation of Russian society and the creation of a socialist state under their leadership.
Representative of the Mensheviks 	The Mensheviks, a rival faction to the Bolsheviks, represented a more moderate current within the Russian socialist movement during the Civil War. Unlike the Bolsheviks, who advocated for an immediate revolution and the establishment of a communist government, the Mensheviks proposed a gradual and democratic approach to achieving socialism, supporting a broad coalition that included the middle classes and the bourgeoisie in the revolutionary process. During the conflict, they opposed the authoritarian methods of the Bolsheviks and criticized their unilateral seizure of power. However, throughout the war, the Mensheviks were weakened, unable to rival the organization and determination of the Bolsheviks, becoming a minority and a marginalized faction. Meanwhile, the Bolsheviks consolidated their dominance and established the communist regime. The actions of the Mensheviks highlighted the internal divisions within the socialist movement and the clash between different visions for political and social transformation in Russia.
United States	During the Russian Civil War, the United States officially adopted a policy of non-intervention in the internal Russian conflict.

	However, they provided military, financial, and logistical support to anti-Soviet groups, including the White Army, motivated by the goal of containing the expansion of communism and protecting their economic and geopolitical interests in the region. Furthermore, the US demonstrated concern for the security of the newly established Democratic Republic of Poland, which was involved in conflicts with the Soviet Union. Despite this support, American participation was limited and did not have a decisive impact on the outcome of the Russian Civil War.
France 	France, as one of the nations who suffered the most from the Great War, was in dire need of resources and economic stability. Its intervention in the Russian Civil War had the main intent of preventing the nationalization of Russian industries, which were built upon French capital and were a major source of income, and expanding French influence into Eastern Europe, mainly Ukraine. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Georges Clemenceau, the French government viewed the Bolsheviks as a threat to the balance of power in Europe and sought to contain the spread of communism. France provided military, financial, and logistical aid, including weapons, ammunition, and military advisors, and pressured other European nations to participate in the intervention in Russia. This support was motivated by geopolitical, ideological, and economic interests, with the expectation of restoring stability in Eastern Europe and protecting its interests in the region. However, like the United States, French involvement was limited and not decisive in the outcome of the conflict.

Poland 	Poland played an important role in the events surrounding the Russian Civil War. After regaining its independence in 1918 following more than a century of foreign rule, the newly established Polish state faced the challenge of securing its borders and protecting its sovereignty. The instability caused by the Russian Civil War quickly spread beyond Russia's borders, creating tensions between Poland and Soviet Russia. These tensions eventually led to the Polish–Soviet War in 1919, making Poland an important regional actor in the conflict. While Soviet forces sought to expand their influence westward, Poland worked to defend its independence and territorial interests. Due to its strategic location between Western Europe and revolutionary Russia, Poland became a key actor in shaping the political future of Eastern Europe during this period.
Italy 	Italy was another European nation to play an important role in the events surrounding the Russian Civil War. Following the end of the Great War, the Italian government closely followed the growing instability within the former Russian Empire and the rise of the Bolshevik government. At a moment where economic difficulties, political unrest, generalized instability and the ever growing popularity of socialist movements, Italian authorities quickly grew concerned over the rise of Bolshevism. These concerns gradually brought Italy closer to the anti-Bolshevik forces fighting in Russia. Although its involvement remained considerably smaller than that of powers such as Britain and France, Italy nevertheless supported Allied efforts against the Bolsheviks and favored the White Movement during the conflict. Consequently, by September 1919, Italy saw the outcome of the Russian Civil War as an important matter not only for Russia itself, but also for the future political stability of Europe.

United Kingdom



The United Kingdom played an important role in the events surrounding the Russian Civil War. Following the Bolshevik seizure of power in October 1917 and Russia's withdrawal from the Great War through the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, British authorities became increasingly concerned over the future of Eastern Europe and the growing influence of revolutionary socialism throughout the continent. At a moment when Europe was still recovering from the devastating effects of the Great War, many British politicians saw the Bolshevik government as a potential threat to the region's already fragile stability.

In this context, Britain began supporting anti-Bolshevik forces during the Civil War, providing military equipment, financial assistance and limited military support to several White Army commanders. However, despite its opposition to the Bolsheviks, the British government remained hesitant to become directly involved in another major conflict, as years of war had generated widespread fatigue amongst both politicians and the population. Consequently, by September 1919, the United Kingdom continued to support the White Movement while avoiding a broader military intervention, seeking to contain Bolshevik influence without becoming fully committed to the conflict.

Japanese Empire



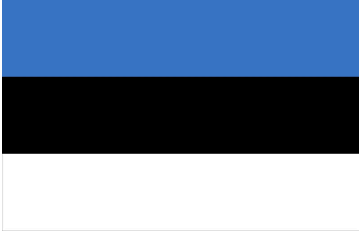
The Japanese Empire, despite not being ideologically related to the European nations or Allies, was the most present nation in the interventionist forces, deploying more than 70,000 men to Siberia. Such levels of participation in the Civil War lied in the Empire's crescent hatred towards communism, territorial disputes dating back to the Russo-Japanese War and the necessity to address the security problems posed by Russia.

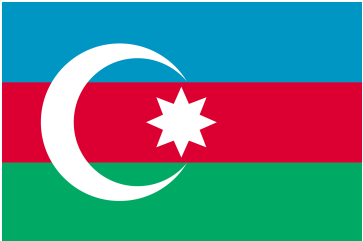
To the Japanese Empire, supporting the Whites means not only the eradication of a feared ideology but also

	the possibility to recoup historical losses and expand its influence in Asia.
Finland 	Finland was a nation heavily affected by the Russian Civil War, even if it had not been directly involved, due to its own civil war and the Soviet influence in it. In 1918, the country found itself torn apart between two political groups – socialists and liberals – seeking to shape the newly independent government, this political tension quickly escalated into a violent bloodshed that ultimately ended with the loss of socialists. Finland now strives to reconstruct and stabilize itself, actively suppressing revolutionary movements and getting ideologically closer to Western powers.
German Republic 	The German Republic encountered itself in a deep political and economic crisis following the end of The Great War. The newly founded government was born in a context of internal political turmoil, social disbelief and dissatisfaction as expectancy and opinions varied greatly from all sectors of society: the army felt like the peace treaty was a betrayal and the war was never lost, while civilians had to deal with a severe food shortage and a political development that did not go their way. In this context, German society grew unsatisfied with their conditions and the Republic itself, seeking radical or extremist options to solve the ongoing crisis To Germany, the Russian Civil War represented a threat to Europe's and its own stability, as the bolshevik revolution inspired Germans to start their own, be it aligned or not with socialism. Therefore, finding a quick solution to the civil war is a crucial step to the maintaining and future of the republic.

Ukrainian Soviet Socialist Republic 	Established after the end of the Ukrainian Civil War, the Ukrainian Soviet Socialist Republic (SSR) was one of the few supporters of the Bolsheviks during the Russian Civil War. Heavily influenced by Lenin's writings, the nation was a firm believer of the internationalization of the revolution and sought to bring communism to all of Europe
Ottoman Empire 	The Ottoman Empire, one of the major geopolitical powers following World War I, faced political instability and territorial losses in 1919 after its defeat as a member of the Central Powers, raising regional and international concerns about its territorial future and governance. The Ottoman Empire ruled vast territories across Europe, the Middle East, and North Africa for over six centuries. However, by the early 20th century, internal crises and military defeats had weakened the state. A historic rival of Russia, it competed for influence in the Balkans and the Black Sea, and during World War I it joined Germany and Austria-Hungary against Russia. The Russian Revolution of 1917 and Russia's withdrawal from World War I reduced pressure on the Ottoman Empire. However, after its defeat, the Empire faced foreign occupation and Allied intervention. In 1919, it sought to preserve its sovereignty while nationalist movements led by Mustafa Kemal gained strength, paving the way for the Empire's dissolution and the creation of modern Turkey.
Kingdom of Serbs, Croats and Slovenes 	The Kingdom of Serbs, Croats and Slovenes was one of the new states created in the aftermath of World War I and the collapse of the major European empires. Before its creation, the territories of the Kingdom were part of larger empires, mainly the Austro-Hungarian and, to a lesser extent, the Ottoman Empire. Their defeat after World War I led to the formation of the Kingdom of Serbs, Croats, and Slovenes. The Kingdom

	was not directly involved in the Russian Civil War, but it faced significant effects. Anti-Bolshevik Russian refugees settled there, creating cultural and educational institutions. In 1919, the Kingdom aimed to unify politically and strengthen its position in postwar Europe. It also worked to govern a diverse population with varying histories and identities.
Republic of China  	Despite a considerably smaller involvement and direct participation in the Russian Civil War when compared to nations like Britain or France, China also played an important role in the conflict. During this period, the country was facing its own political instability, as the Beiyang Government struggled to consolidate its authority amidst the growing influence of regional warlords. At the same time, the growing instability in Russia raised concerns amongst Chinese authorities, particularly in regions bordering Siberia, where commercial interests and Chinese communities could be directly affected by the conflict. In this context, China joined the Allied intervention in Russia and deployed troops to Siberia, supporting efforts aimed at containing the spread of instability throughout the region and protecting its interests near the Russian border. Consequently, by September 1919, China remained aligned with the Allied powers involved in the conflict while closely monitoring developments in Siberia and the Russian Far East.
Latvia 	Latvia faced significant change during the Russian Revolution and Civil War. It shifted from being part of the Russian Empire to gaining independence amid competing political and military forces. Before 1918, Latvia was under Russian Empire rule, leading to economic inequality and limited political representation. World War I and the Russian Revolution caused major disruptions, fostering support for revolutionary ideas. The Latvian Riflemen were a key military group formed in the Russian Imperial Army.

	During the Russian Civil War, Latvia supported the Bolsheviks and protected leaders such as Lenin. In 1918, amid a strong nationalist movement, Latvia declared independence but faced challenges from German and Bolshevik forces. In 1919, Latvia sought to secure sovereignty while navigating overlapping revolutionary and nationalist movements, with Latvians engaged in both sides of the struggle for self-determination.
Republic of Estonia 	Estonia faced major political and military changes during the Russian Revolution and Civil War. It transitioned from being a territory of the Russian Empire to becoming an independent nation while confronting threats from both Bolshevik and German forces. Before 1917, Estonia was part of the Russian Empire, but a strong national identity had developed during the late 19th century. The collapse of imperial authority during the Russian Revolution created an opportunity for Estonians to pursue self-determination. In 1918, Estonia declared its independence and began the difficult process of establishing a sovereign state. By 1919, Estonia had successfully resisted Bolshevik attacks and strengthened its independence. Its victory showed how the Russian Revolution weakened the Russian Empire and allowed smaller nations to become independent. Estonia became one of the first independent Baltic states and gained international recognition.
Lithuania 	After declaring its independence in 1918, the newly established Lithuanian state faced the challenge of securing its borders and consolidating its sovereignty amidst the political instability that spread all throughout Eastern Europe following the end of the Great War. As Bolshevik forces advanced into the country's territory in late 1918, the conflict quickly became more than a domestic Russian matter, directly threatening the country's recently achieved independence.

	These events eventually led to the Lithuanian–Soviet War, making Lithuania an important regional actor in the conflict. More than an ideological conflict, the state became involved in the war mostly to defend its own sovereignty as a new-found nation. While Soviet Russia sought to expand its influence into the Baltic region, Lithuania worked to preserve its independence and maintain control over its territory. Due to such a strategic position along Russia's western frontier, Lithuania became an important part of the broader struggle for political control in Eastern Europe during this period.
Azerbaijan 	Following the collapse of the Russian Empire, Azerbaijan declared its independence in 1918 with the creation of the Azerbaijan Democratic Republic. However, the country's position remained highly unstable, as political and military tensions caused by the Russian Civil War quickly spread throughout the Caucasus. At the same time, the oil fields of Baku attracted the attention of both the Bolsheviks and the White Movement, as well as foreign powers interested in maintaining influence over the region. In this scenario, the nation mainly focused on preserving its recently achieved independence while attempting to avoid becoming directly involved in the conflict. Despite the nation's wishes, the continuation of the Civil War made this more and more difficult, since developments inside Russia had a direct impact on the political future of the Caucasus. By September 1919, Azerbaijan remained independent, but the uncertainty surrounding the conflict continued to threaten the country's sovereignty.

Hungary



The political instability that followed the end of the Great War directly shaped the Hungarian Government's stance when addressing the Russian Civil War. In 1919, the establishment of the Hungarian Soviet Republic brought the country closer to Bolshevik Russia, as its leaders sought to build a communist government inspired by the October Revolution. However, the collapse of the regime only a few months later completely changed Hungary's political situation, leading to the formation of a new government while the country continued to face serious political and territorial challenges.

In this scenario, the events taking place in Russia remained a matter of great importance for Hungary. Although the new government no longer supported the Bolsheviks, its main focus was restoring internal stability after months of political turmoil and military conflict. By September 1919, Hungary closely followed the developments of the Russian Civil War, recognizing that its outcome would have important consequences for the balance of power in Central and Eastern Europe.

Historical Events and Acts

Bloody Sunday (January 22, 1905)	On January 22, 1905, a significant event occurred when thousands of workers and their families marched peacefully towards the Winter Palace in St. Petersburg to present a petition to Tsar Nicholas II. The demonstration, led by Father Georgy Gapon, aimed to demand improved working conditions, increased wages, and basic political representation. However, the demonstration turned tragic when imperial troops opened fire on the unarmed crowd, resulting in hundreds of casualties. This tragic event, known as Bloody Sunday, profoundly altered public perception of the Tsar as a benevolent figure. The massacre sparked widespread outrage, leading to a wave of strikes, protests, and unrest throughout the Russian Empire. Ultimately, Bloody Sunday acted as a vital catalyst for the Revolution of 1905, representing a crucial turning point in the growing opposition to autocratic rule.
The Russian Revolution (1905)	The Russian Empire faced social, economic, and political tensions in the early 20th century, marked by rapid industrialization, poor working conditions, and an autocratic government. The year 1905 was marked by strikes, peasant uprisings, student protests, and military mutinies, all demanding constitutional and labor reforms, leading to the emergence of the soviets, which coordinated the strikes. The revolution did not overthrow the Romanov monarchy, but it undermined the legitimacy of the tsarist regime, exposed the empire's structural problems, and provided political lessons for future revolutionary movements that led to the monarchy's downfall in 1917.
February Revolution (1917)	The February Revolution began with strikes, food shortages, and mass protests in Petrograd during World War I. Over time, soldiers joined the protesters and refused to suppress the uprising, leading Tsar Nicholas II

	to abdicate and bringing an end to more than three centuries of Romanov rule. While a Provisional Government took power, workers' and soldiers' councils—known as soviets—also gained strength. This structure of dual power created political instability and paved the way for even greater revolutionary changes.
October Revolution (1917)	The October Revolution of 1917, also known as the Bolshevik Revolution, was one of the most significant events of the 20th century. Taking place on October 25th according to the Julian calendar (November 7th according to the Gregorian calendar), it resulted in the Bolsheviks, led by Lenin, seizing power in Russia. This event marked the beginning of the communist regime in the country, triggered the Russian Civil War, and laid the foundations for the formation of the Soviet state, with profound repercussions on world politics.
Declaration of the Soviet State (1917)	Following the October Revolution, the Bolsheviks established Soviet authority and the Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic (RSFSR). Led by Vladimir Lenin, the new government replaced the Provisional Government, transferred formal power to the Soviets, and centralized authority within the Bolshevik Party, creating the world's first socialist state and sparking the Russian Civil War against anti-Bolshevik forces.
Signing of the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk (1918)	The Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, signed in March 1918 between Soviet Russia and the Central Powers, led by Germany, marked Russia's withdrawal from World War I. In exchange for peace, Russia ceded vast territories, including areas of Poland, Ukraine, Finland, and the Baltic countries. This peace, considered humiliating, had profound political and economic consequences for Soviet Russia, intensifying internal tensions and triggering subsequent conflicts.
Creation of the Red Army (1918)	Shortly after the signing of the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, the Bolsheviks established the Red Army to defend the

	young Soviet Republic against multiple internal and external enemies. Under the leadership of Leon Trotsky, the Red Army played a crucial role in the Bolsheviks' survival and victory in the Russian Civil War, establishing itself as one of the most powerful military forces of its time.
Beginning of foreign intervention (1918)	Following the October Revolution, several foreign powers, such as the United Kingdom, France, Japan, and the United States, intervened militarily in Russia to support the opponents of the Bolsheviks in the Russian Civil War. This external intervention aggravated the internal conflict, prolonging the war and resulting in high human and material costs for all parties involved.
Execution of the Romanov Family (1918)	On the night of July 16–17, 1918, Tsar Nicholas II, Empress Alexandra, their five children, and several loyal servants were executed by Bolshevik forces in Yekaterinburg. The murders were intended to prevent the former imperial family from becoming a rallying point for the White Army forces advancing in the region. The execution marked the definitive end of the Romanov dynasty, which had ruled Russia since 1613. This remains one of the most symbolic and controversial events of the Russian Revolution.
Baltic Independence Wars (1918–1920)	Following the collapse of the Russian Empire, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania declared independence and waged wars against Bolshevik and German-backed forces. These conflicts were deeply intertwined with the Russian Civil War, as the Red Army sought at all costs to restore Soviet control over the region. Thanks to internal resistance and foreign support, the Baltic States managed to defend their sovereignty. These victories ultimately weakened Bolshevik influence in northwestern Europe and cemented the three countries' status as independent nations.

Azerbaijan Democratic Republic and Sovietization (1918–1920)	In May 1918, Azerbaijan declared independence and established the Democratic Republic of Azerbaijan, becoming the first democratic and secular republic in the Muslim world. The new state faced internal instability and regional conflicts as it struggled to survive amid the ruins of the Russian Empire. In April 1920, the Red Army invaded the territory, overthrew the republic, and imposed Soviet rule. This Sovietization strengthened Bolshevik control over the Caucasus and secured strategic access to the rich oil fields of Baku.
Polish Intervention and the Polish–Soviet War (1919–1921)	The Polish intervention in Russia in 1919 initiated the Polish–Soviet War, a conflict of great importance to Eastern Europe. Characterized by intense battles and significant territorial changes, the war culminated in a Soviet victory, where the Soviets repelled Polish forces and consolidated their control over Ukraine and Belarus.

Glossary

Duma	The Duma was a lower house of the Russian parliament established by the October manifesto after the revolution of 1905. It had power to propose and or vote on laws that would be sent to Tsar's approval
Liberal	A supporter of the Liberalism political and economic philosophy. Represented by the bourgeoisie, liberals stands for economic and individual liberties above anything else, believing that the state should not meddle with personal affairs neither with economy
NCOs	NCOs are military personnel in positions of authority earned by promotion instead of appointment or through military academies. NCOs are considered the backbone of every army due to acting as a bridge between low and high-ranking personnel.
Proletariat	The sector of the working class whose possession of significant economic value is their labour power, described in marxist theory as those exploited and oppressed by the bourgeoisie, capable of revolutionary action to overcome capitalism.
Red Scare	A nationwide anti-radical hysteria provoked by a mounting fear and anxiety that a Bolshevik revolution in America was imminent. Red Scare also heavily influenced American politics, with Congress passing many acts in order to protect the nation from conspiratory movements and terrorist attacks.
Soviets	Soviets were workers councils established in the 1905 revolution in order to organize and lead the working class throughout strikes, political and military fights against the government. The soviets were a key factor that led to the radicalization of Russia's proletariat and the creation of the Bolshevik party
Tsar	Slavic term used to refer to the ruler of a kingdom
Zaamurets	Armored trains made to fight in the Great War but mainly used during the Russian Civil by the Bolsheviks, the Whites and the Czechoslovak Legion.

List of Countries

Azerbaijan	Official member
Bolsheviks	Official member
China	Official member
Estonia	Official member
Finland	Official member
France	Official member
Germany	Official member
Hungary	Official member
Italy	Official member
Japan	Official member
Kingdom of Serbs, Croats and Slovenes	Official member
Lithuania	Official member
Latvia	Official member
Mensheviks	Official member
Ottoman Empire	Official member
Poland	Official member
Russian Empire	Official member
United Kingdom	Official member
United States	Official member
Ukraine	Official member

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PICTURES

Figure 1 – EVERETT COLLECTION, unknown photographer. Russians camped out during the famines of 1918–1921. WWI, the Russian Revolution, the civil war, and drought contributed to crop and food distribution failure. Available on: <https://www.shutterstock.com/pt/image-photo/russians-camped-out-during-famines-19181921-785842318>

Figure 2 – VLADIMIROV, Ivan. File: The Russian Revolution, 1905. Available on: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:The_Russian_Revolution,_1905_Q81561.jpg